

The Parent & Grandparent Conversation Guide

Protect the Most-Targeted Generation — Without Scaring Them Into Silence

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The people most targeted by voice-clone scams are also the hardest to reach. Fear-based warnings make them anxious and defensive. This guide shows you how to actually protect them — with love, not lectures.

The One Sentence That Changes Everything

"Mom, I want us to have a code word — just for emergencies. If I ever call you in real trouble, I'll say it, and you'll know it's really me. And if someone calls claiming to be me and doesn't know the word, you'll know it's a fake and you can hang up safely. It's my job to look out for you, and this is how I do it."

Why this works: it frames the protocol as *their child protecting them*, not as *the world being scary*. It gives them a concrete job (remember the word) instead of a vague fear.

The Two-Question Method (Make It Their Idea)

Step 1 — Open gently: *"Have you heard about those calls where they copy a voice? It's been in the news a lot."*

Let them tell you what they know. Correct gently, don't lecture.

Step 2 — Let them choose: *"Would it feel safer if we had a way to know it's really me every time?"*

Now it's their decision, not your lecture. People protect what they choose.

The Three Rules (Keep It This Simple)

Older adults do best with exactly three rules. Don't add a fourth.

1. **The word.** *"We have one word. If I ever call in trouble, I'll say it. Anyone who can't say it is not me."*
 2. **The call-back.** *"If someone asks for money, hang up and call me back on MY number."*
 3. **The group.** *"You're in the family group. If you're ever unsure, post there — we'll answer in minutes."*
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How to Rehearse Without Scaring

The practice call (do it at a calm moment):

"Okay Mom, pretend I'm a scammer. I'm calling you in a panic saying I'm in jail. What do you do?"

Walk through it. Praise the correct behavior: *"YES! You asked for the word! That's exactly right!"*

Why rehearsal matters: in a real panic, people don't *think* — they *react*. Repetition builds the reflex so the right behavior is automatic, not a judgment call made under stress.

Re-drill every 6 months. Put a calendar reminder on your phone.

What NOT To Do

- **Don't show scary videos of cloned voices.** Creates anxiety without building skills.
 - **Don't shame them for almost falling for it.** Shame kills the reporting reflex — which is the single most valuable thing they can do.
 - **Don't make the safe word a family joke posted on Facebook.** Public defeats the purpose.
 - **Don't overwhelm them with statistics.** One conversation about the word is worth ten about the \$893M in losses.
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If They've Already Been Targeted

- **Reassure first:** *"This is not your fault. This is a crime. Millions of smart people have been targeted."*
 - **Get the details:** what did the caller say, what number, what did they ask for?
 - **Run the Recovery Playbook** if money moved — hour 0 matters.
 - **Report together:** sit with them and file the IC3 report. It's empowering, not scary, when done together.
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The Script They Need On Paper

Print this and put it by their phone:

**If someone calls and says a family member is in trouble
and needs money:**

1. Ask for the word.
2. If they don't know it — HANG UP.
3. Call your family member back on their real number.
4. Tell the family group.
5. Never send money to someone you can't verify.

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